

AN EXPLORATORY EXAMINATION OF THE FACTORS INFLUENCING THE ORIGINATION, CONTINUATION, AND CESSATION OF IDENTIFICATION WITH SPORTS TEAMS¹

DANIEL L. WANN, KATHLEEN B. TUCKER, AND MICHAEL P. SCHRADER

Murray State University

Summary.—While previous work had focused on the manner in which identification with a sports team influences the reactions of spectators, research had yet to identify those factors with the greatest amount of influence on identification. This article reports on an exploratory study designed to fill this void by identifying the factors involved in the origination, continuation, and cessation of sports-team identification. Responses indicated that a wide variety of factors were perceived by fans to be important in their identification. Specifically, the success of the team, geographical reasons, the players, and affiliative reasons were all quite important in the fans' identification.

Although researchers have examined the effects of identification on spectators' behaviors (e.g., Branscombe & Wann, 1992; Simons & Taylor, 1992; Wann, 1993; Wann, Dolan, McGeorge, & Allison, 1994), they have neglected to examine the factors that influence identification. While research had documented that factors such as a preference for active pastimes, tendencies to be involved with sport as an athlete as well as a spectator, and higher socioeconomic status are related to sports viewing or attendance (Crossman, 1986; Gantz, 1981; Prisuta, 1979; Schurr, Wittig, Ruble, & Ellen, 1988), work had yet to specify variables playing the greatest roles in identification with a particular team. The current study was designed to fill this void. Given the exploratory nature of this research, no formal hypotheses were generated. Rather, the current work set out to examine the research question of what factors are involved in the identification of a specific sports team. Three aspects of identification were examined, the continuation, origination, and cessation of spectators' identification.

METHOD

Undergraduate psychology student volunteers (44 men, 47 women) participated for extra course credit. The subjects' mean age was 24.3 yr.

After reading, signing, and returning an informed consent statement, subjects (tested in groups of 10 to 25) were asked to complete a five-page questionnaire packet. The first page asked students to list their currently fa-

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favorite sports team (amateur or professional) and to complete the Sport Spectator Identification Scale (Wann & Branscombe, 1993) with that team as the target. This scale has seven items with strong reliability and validity (see Wann & Branscombe, 1993). Page two presented subjects 40 lines on which they were to list the reasons why they currently followed the team listed on page one. They were told to be complete in their responses, listing each reason no matter how trivial. Page three again presented 40 lines and required that subjects list the reasons they originally began to follow the team listed on page one. Again, respondents were asked to be complete in their responses. In addition, they were informed that the reasons did not have to be different from those listed on page two. On page four of the packet, subjects were to list a sports team that they previously considered a favorite but no longer cared for. They then completed the scale with this formerly favorite team as the target. On the final page subjects listed the reasons why they stopped following the team listed on page four. As with the previous lists, subjects were given 40 lines on which to write and were told that they were to be complete in their responses. The questionnaire packets required approximately 30 minutes to complete. After all subjects had completed and returned the packets, they were debriefed concerning the nature of the research and then excused from the testing session.

RESULTS

Gender Differences

Gender differences were not found on ratings on the Sport Spectator Identification Scale (men's $M_s = 4.88$ and 2.20 , women's $M_s = 5.19$ and 2.87 for the current and former favorites, respectively; all $p_s > .08$), and men and women did not report a differential number of reasons on any of the three lists (team currently followed: men's $M = 6.77$, women's $M = 5.70$; team originally followed: men's $M = 3.55$, women's $M = 3.38$; team ceased to follow: men's $M = 2.98$, women's $M = 2.95$; all $p_s > .15$). Thus, the analyses reported here were conducted across gender. Five subjects (all women) did not list a formerly favorite team. Thus, the analyses reported below were computed on an N of 91 for the current and original lists and on an N of 86 for the list involving reasons why they stopped following the team.

Indexes of Identification

The seven items comprising the scale for both the current and former favorite teams were each combined to form two separate indexes of identification (Cronbach alpha = .93 for both indexes). A one-way repeated-measures analysis of variance computed on the means for these scales indicated that identification was higher for the current favorite team ($M = 5.03$) than for the former favorite ($M = 2.53$; $F_{1,84} = 146.94$, $p < .0001$).

Each of the three lists of reasons (currently, originally, and ceased following the team) was analyzed individually. It should be noted that the three lists were correlated. The number of reasons subjects currently followed a team and the number listed for originally following a team ($r_{89} = .52$, $p < .0001$), the number of reasons for currently following a team and those reported for no longer supporting a team ($r_{84} = .37$, $p < .0001$), and the number of reasons listed for originally and no longer following a team ($r_{84} = .22$, $p < .02$) were all positively and significantly related.

To estimate consistency among the reasons listed for originally, continuing, and ceasing to follow a sport team, the three lists of reasons were ranked and analyzed using a Spearman rank-order correlation (rho). Reasons not applicable to one or more lists were omitted from the analyses. The Spearman $rhos$ indicated each list was positively and significantly correlated: currently/originally, $rho = .78$, $z = 5.41$, $p < .01$; currently/no longer, $rho = .50$, $z = 3.47$, $p < .01$; originally/no longer, $rho = .52$, $z = 3.60$, $p < .01$.

Reasons for Currently Following Their Favorite Team

Subjects listed a total of 566 reasons for currently following their favorite sports team, a mean of 6.22 responses per subject ($SD = 3.84$). The minimum number of reasons listed was 1, with the maximum being 19 for a range of 18 reasons. The modal number of reasons was 5 (listed by 18.7% of the respondents). Very few subjects (6.6%) reported only one reason for currently identifying with the team. The reasons were placed into categories based on type, e.g., geographical reasons, the success of the team, etc., resulting in 48 different categories of responses. Subjects could have more than one response in a single category. For example, if a subject stated that her favorite team was the Chicago Bulls professional basketball team and then stated that the reason she started to follow this team was because she liked Michael Jordan and Scottie Pippen, then this individual would have received two entries in the "liked the players" category. The percentages of subjects listing the various types of reasons are listed in Table 1. The five most common reasons listed for currently following one's favorite team were (1) the team was successful (16.1%), (2) they liked the players or because the players were good (13.3%), (3) geographical reasons were specified (9.7%), (4) their friends or peers follow the team and they enjoy the group affiliations resulting from following the team (8.7%), and (5) their parents or family followed the team (5.5%).

Reasons for Originally Following The Favorite Team

Subjects listed a total of 315 reasons for originally following the favorite team, averaging 3.46 responses per individual ($SD = 2.27$). The minimum number of reasons listed was 1, while the maximum was 16 resulting in a range of 15. The modal number of reasons was 3 (listed by 23.1% of the

TABLE 1
PERCENTAGE OF RESPONSES FOR CURRENTLY, ORIGINALLY, AND NO LONGER FOLLOWING THE TEAM

Response	Currently	Originally	No Longer
They are a successful/talented team.	16.1 ₁	7.9 ₅	11.8 ₁
Geographical reasons (like the town, city, or state this team represents and/or I live in or around the area).	9.7 ₃	9.8 ₃	5.9 ₄
The players, that is, because I like the players and/or because they are good.	13.3 ₂	10.2 ₂	0.8
My parents and/or family follow this team.	5.5 ₅	12.4 ₁	2.8
My friends and peers follow this team and I like the group affiliations and friendships I acquire.	8.7 ₄	9.8 ₃	5.5 ₅
I had too many other commitments and/or I simply did not have time.	na	na	6.3 ₂
The loss of certain team players.	na	na	6.3 ₂
I like the sport in which this team participates.	5.1	3.8	4.3
I like the trades this team makes.	0.2	0.0	5.1
I simply lost interest.	na	na	5.1
This team represents a school I now, have, or hope to attend.	2.7	3.8	5.1
They receive a substantial amount of radio, television, and/or newspaper media coverage.	1.4	3.5	3.9
I like the coaching staff.	3.4	1.0	2.0
I like the feelings of excitement and/or anxiety I feel when watching them play.	1.6	4.1	2.0
I like the management and/or owners of this team.	1.1	0.6	3.1
I can see them play in person.	1.4	2.9	2.8
I like their style of play.	2.5	2.9	2.0
I like the team's uniform, colors, name, mascot, and/or logo.	3.0	2.9	1.6
I know the names of the players.	0.7	1.0	1.5
It is a fun and enjoyable form of entertainment.	2.1	1.0	1.2
I am or want to be a cheerleader for this team.	0.2	0.6	0.8
It is expected/required of me.	0.2	0.3	1.2
I know, have met with, and/or am friends with the players.	1.8	1.9	0.8
I like this team's announcers.	0.7	0.3	0.4
This team is the underdog.	1.2	0.6	0.4
They have a good future.	0.2	0.0	0.4
I like their home stadium/arena.	0.7	0.0	0.4
Economic reasons, that is, because I received cheap free tickets or because I like to bet on this team.	0.9	2.2	0.4
I like the team's reputation and image.	0.4	0.6	0.4
I like the players' off-court or off-field activities.	0.9	0.0	0.8
I like the team's tradition.	0.4	1.6	0.4
I like their aggressiveness.	0.4	0.3	0.8
It helps relieve my boredom.	0.7	3.2	0.0

(continued on next page)

Note.—na indicates that the response was not applicable to that list. Subscript numbers indicate the five most common responses for each of the three columns. Items such as 'I dislike the team's rivals' and 'I like their style of play' should be reworded for the 'no longer' column, i.e., these items would read 'I no longer disliked the team's rivals' and 'I no longer liked their style of play.'

TABLE 1 (CONT'D)
PERCENTAGE OF RESPONSES FOR CURRENTLY, ORIGINALLY, AND NO LONGER FOLLOWING THE TEAM

Response	Currently	Originally	No Longer
I like to follow the other teams.	0.7	0.0	0.0
I am currently playing in a fantasy sports league involving this team and/or its players.	0.4	na	na
It helps me learn about the sport.	0.5	1.0	0.0
I have autographs of some of the players.	0.2	0.3	0.0
I know the owner, manager, and/or coaches.	1.1	1.0	0.0
The players have good attitudes, are motivated, and/or demonstrate a high level of sportsmanship.	2.3	1.3	1.6
I like the team's band.	0.2	0.3	0.0
The team's cohesiveness and unity.	0.4	0.0	1.2
I dislike the team's rivals.	1.6	0.3	0.0
I like the team's fight song.	0.4	0.6	0.0
The team is popular.	0.7	1.6	0.0
I always have.	2.1	na	na
I like the league the team represents.	0.4	0.2	0.0
I used to play for this team.	0.4	0.6	0.4
I like to be different.	0.4	0.6	0.0
I DISLIKE this team's players, coaches, and/or owner.	0.5	0.3	0.8
I like following the team's statistics.	0.5	0.0	0.0
The players and/or coaches are physically attractive.	0.7	1.3	0.0
They played a popular sport.	0.0	0.3	0.4
I preferred college teams.	0.0	0.3	0.4
They were a young team.	0.0	0.3	0.0
The team folded.	na	na	0.8
A lack of knowledge about the sport.	na	na	0.4
I grew up.	na	na	2.4
I stopped playing the sport.	na	na	0.4
I simply switched allegiance to another team.	na	na	3.9
They were over-rated and/or too successful.	na	na	1.6

Note.—na indicates that the response was not applicable to that list. Subscript numbers indicate the five most common responses for each of the three columns. Items such as 'I dislike the team's rivals' and 'I like their style of play' should be reworded for the 'no longer' column, i.e., these items would read 'I no longer disliked the team's rivals' and 'I no longer liked their style of play.'

subjects). Again, only 15.4% of subjects reported only one reason. The reasons were again placed into categories based on type, resulting in 42 different categories of responses (see Table 1). The five most common reasons listed for originally following a specific team were (1) their parents or family followed the team (12.4%), (2) they liked the players or the players were good (13.3%), (3 and 4) their friends or peers follow the team and they enjoy the group affiliations resulting from following the team and geographical reasons (9.8% each), and (5) the team is successful (7.9%).

Reasons For No Longer Following the Formerly Favorite Team

Subjects listed a total of 255 reasons for ceasing to follow a formerly fa-

vorite team ($M=2.97$, $SD=1.42$). The minimum number of reasons listed was 1, the maximum being 7 resulting in a range of 6. The modal number of reasons was 3 (listed by 31.9% of the participants). Of the subjects 19.8% listed only a single reason. The reasons were again grouped into categories based on type, resulting in 44 different categories of responses (see Table 1). Please note that the phrasing of these responses, i.e., no longer following the team, was different from that of the other two lists. For example, items such as "I dislike the team's rivals," listed as a reason for currently or originally following the team, would read "I *no longer* disliked the team's greatest rivals" in the list of reasons for ceasing to follow the team. The five most commonly reported reasons for ceasing to follow a team were (1) they were no longer a successful team (11.8%), (2 and 3) respondents had too many other commitments or simply did not have the time and the loss of certain players (6.3% each), (4) geographical reasons were given (5.9%), and (5) their friends or peers no longer followed the team and they no longer enjoyed the group affiliations resulting from following the team (5.5%).

Spearman *rhos* to assess consistency among the above sets of reasons were ranked and correlated positively.

DISCUSSION

The most apparent finding was the large number and variety of reasons underscoring the origination, continuation, and cessation of identification with a sport team. For each of the three types of identification, over 40 different reasons for identification were listed. Three factors were listed in the top five influences on each list, the success of the team, geographical concerns, and the fact that friends and peers followed the team, i.e., affiliative reasons. As for success of the team, this finding most likely represents fans' tendencies to bask in the glory of the team (Cialdini, Borden, Thorne, Walker, Freeman, & Sloan, 1976). The importance of geographic needs in all probability reflects the effort required to follow the team through the media or in person as well as the increased media exposure given to local teams. Certainly, research has found that increased exposure to a variety of stimuli increases the attractiveness of the stimuli, including exposure to sports teams (Wann, in press; Wann & Weaver, 1993). The importance of affiliation apparently reflects the social nature of sports spectating. Similarly, one's parents and family were common reasons for the origination and continuation of identification. Finally, the players themselves also played a major role as the abilities and traits of the players were important for the origination and continuation of identification while the loss of specific players was a major factor in the cessation of identification.

Conclusion

The current exploratory study indicated that there are several factors

which play a role in the origination, continuation, and cessation of identification with sports teams. The success of the team, geographical reasons, the players, and affiliative reasons were all particularly important. It should be mentioned, however, that this research should simply be considered as the first step in understanding the factors involved in identification with sport teams. Other research, building on the study reported here, should attempt to develop testable hypotheses and examine these predictions using other, possibly more sophisticated methodologies such as longitudinal or experimental research. Further, the data were self-reported and the sample was relatively small and homogeneous. Thus, further research should acquire other indications of reasons underlying the origin, continuation, and cessation of team identification using different age, race, and geographic populations, perhaps by manipulating team identifications in a longitudinal fashion and examining factors responsible for higher and lower allegiance.

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HEIGHT AND PERCEIVED COMPETENCE OF U.S. PRESIDENTS¹

THOMAS J. YOUNG

Beatrice, Nebraska

AND

LAURENCE A. FRENCH

Western New Mexico University

Summary.—The 4 “great” U.S. Presidents, as listed in the 1982 Murray-Blessing Poll, were significantly taller ($M=74.63$ in.) than the 5 considered “failures” ($M=70.80$ in.), consistent with previous research on height and status.

Gowin (1915), in a classic study, reported that height lends men an economic and social advantage. In a literature review, Freedman (1979) concluded that “being short itself is a problem, at least for men, largely because it is an automatic sign of subdominance, and being tall is automatically a self-esteem booster for the opposite reason” (p. 90).

Given this, one might hypothesize that the “great” U.S. Presidents ($n=4$), as listed in the 1982 Murray-Blessing Poll (see Stanley & Niemi, 1992) would be taller than those perceived as “failures” ($n=5$). King and Ragsdale (1988) reported the following heights in inches for the “great” U.S. Presidents, namely, Lincoln (76), F. Roosevelt (74), Washington (74), and Jefferson (74.5). For those perceived as “failures,” the heights in inches were, namely, A. Johnson (70), Buchanan (72), Nixon (71.5), Grant (68.5), and Harding (72).

The “great” U.S. Presidents were significantly taller ($M=74.63$ in., $SD=0.94$) than those perceived as “failures” ($M=70.80$ in., $SD=1.53$; $t=4.35$, one-tailed $p<.005$), supporting the hypothesis derived from Freedman. While all of the “great” U.S. Presidents were over six feet in height, none of the perceived “failures” were taller than six feet. Abraham Lincoln, the tallest U.S. President, was ranked in the Murray-Blessing Poll as the “greatest.” Of course, it is important not to overstate the case for tallness. As Freedman (1979) pointed out, “if one is too far beyond the population average, disadvantages begin to accrue” (p. 92).

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¹Address correspondence to Thomas J. Young, Ph.D., 121 South LaSalle Street, Beatrice, NE 68310.